Hermes Agent

for Dummies

A PLAIN-LANGUAGE MANUAL

Memory, skills, the gateway, Bot Mode, and the learning loop, explained without the repository tour.

PREPARED BY

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ABOUT THIS MANUAL

How to read this book

This manual treats Hermes Agent the way a good “for Dummies” book treats a new workshop tool: what it is, where it lives, which file it writes, and the mistake that gives it the keys to the house.

Hermes Agent is the self-improving agent built by Nous Research, the lab behind the Hermes, Nomos, and Psyche model lines. The official line is specific. It creates skills from experience, improves them during use, nudges itself to persist knowledge, and builds a deepening model of who you are across sessions. It is open source. You run it. The model behind it is a choice, not a lock-in.

Four ideas do most of the work. Memory is a short curated notebook. Skills are procedures it can load, write, and improve. The gateway is how the same agent shows up in Telegram, Discord, Slack, and a long list of other rooms. Bot Mode is a team of specialist bots that share a group chat. Everything else hangs off those four.

> PLAIN ENGLISH
> A chat window answers and forgets. An agent in this sense keeps a process, calls tools, and is meant to be less ignorant next week than it was today. Hermes is the second kind.

The marks in the margin

Callout boxes are original to this manual. They mark the sentence worth keeping.

> REMEMBER
> A fact that stays true across installs: a file name, a limit, a boundary between two features.

> TIP
> A command or a habit that saves a broken session.

> WATCH OUT
> A permission, a YOLO switch, or a place where the docs and a blog post disagree.

What this edition is, and is not

This is the 2026 Edition, prepared as an independent study guide by Er. Rishabh Aryan, M.Tech (Artificial Intelligence and Data Science), Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Indian Institute of Information Technology, Bhagalpur (Bihar). It is not published by Nous Research, and it is not part of the Wiley “For Dummies” series. The bronze and gold follow the public default skin of Hermes Agent — banner gold, bronze border, cornsilk paper — as described in the project’s own skin reference. The mark on the cover was drawn for this manual and is not the Nous Research trademark.

Feature names follow the public documentation at hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/docs: the product page, the features overview, the persistent-memory page, and the security page. Commands move between releases. If a flag in this book fails, the install on your machine is the authority, and

hermes doctor is the first question to ask it.

> **WATCH OUT**
> The agent is free to install. The model is not free unless the provider says so. Nous Portal, OpenRouter, OpenAI, and a local model are different bills. Confirm the meter before you leave a cron job running overnight.

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CHAPTER 01

Hermes, without the mythology

Before the install script, it helps to know which object you are about to give a terminal.

Hermes Agent is an autonomous assistant you run yourself. The documentation places it on Linux, macOS, WSL2, native Windows, Nix, Android via Termux, and serverless backends such as Daytona, Modal, and Vercel Sandbox. You talk to it from a terminal, a desktop app, or a messaging gateway. It calls tools: a shell, a file edit, a browser, a search.

It is not a single model. Official setup points at Nous Portal, OpenRouter, OpenAI, or any compatible endpoint. Switching models is a configuration act — the documented command is **hermes model** — not a rewrite of the agent. That is the difference between Hermes and a chat product tied to one lab's subscription.

The four names

Name	In plain English
Hermes Agent	The process you install. It plans, calls tools, and keeps state.
Memory	Two short files, MEMORY.md and USER.md, injected at the start of a session.
Skill	A procedure it can load when the job needs it, and can write after a hard task.
Gateway	The bridge that lets the same agent answer on Telegram, Discord, Slack, and other platforms.
Bot Mode	Specialist bots that work together in group chats and through @mentions.
Nous Portal	Nous Research's hosted path. One setup can cover a model plus web, image, speech, and browser tools.

Names used in the rest of this manual. Release notes add commands; these jobs stay.

What it is not

- Not a chatbot tab that forgets you on refresh. Memory is a file, and it is bounded.
- Not an IDE plugin only. The terminal is home; messaging platforms are rooms it can enter.
- Not Grok Bot. Grok Bot is xAI's hosted teammate. Hermes is a program you run, pointed at a model you choose.
- Not a guarantee of a benchmark. Blog posts cite scores. This book does not. Your task is the test.

> **REMEMBER**
> You are installing a tool-using process, not opening a website. A key, a shell, and a cron job are the three things that can cost you something while you are away.

CHAPTER 02

Install, then the first real job

The documented fast path is an install script, then one setup command that covers a model and four tools.

The documentation's install line for Linux, macOS, and WSL2 is a single fetch-and-run. Native Windows has its own PowerShell line. Read the script if you are on a machine you do not control. Then run setup.

Where	Documented start
Linux, macOS, WSL2	curl -fsSL https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/install.sh | bash
Windows, native	iex (irm https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/install.ps1)
First working agent	hermes setup --portal

From the public install and quickstart pages. A later release may add a package install beside the script.

hermes setup --portal is the documented short path: one sign-in covers a model provider plus the four Tool Gateway tools — web search, image generation, text-to-speech, and browser. If you already have a key for another provider, configuration can point there instead. Do not paste a key into a chat you will later share.

A first job, not a first greeting

"Hello" teaches you nothing. Point Hermes at a folder you can afford to dirty, and give it a job with a definition of done.

- Name the directory. Do not start it in your home folder.
- Say the output: a file, a diff, a summary with quotes from the files.
- Say the prohibition: do not install packages, do not push, do not touch secrets.
- Read the tool output as it streams. Interrupt if the command is not the one you meant.

> **TIP**
> After setup, run hermes doctor before you blame the model. A missing key and a missing tool look the same from the outside: a confident apology.

Profiles, if you have two lives

A profile is a separate Hermes: its own config, sessions, skills, and memory. Use one for a course repository and another for a personal machine. Do not teach the course profile your private calendar, and do not teach the personal profile your institution's unreleased data.

CHAPTER 03

Memory and the learning loop

Hermes does not remember everything. It remembers what fits in two short files, and it can search the rest.

The memory page is unusually concrete. Two files live under **~/.hermes/memories/**, scoped per profile. MEMORY.md is the agent's notebook: environment facts, conventions, things learned. The documented cap is 2,200 characters. USER.md is the profile of you: preferences, style, expectations. The documented cap is 1,375 characters.

Both are injected as a frozen snapshot when a session starts. They do not change in the middle of that session. The agent writes them with a memory tool: add, replace, or remove. There is no read action, because the snapshot is already in the prompt. A new session — **/new** on the CLI and on messaging platforms — is when the updated snapshot is read.

> REMEMBER
> Saving a fact and starting a new session are two steps. A fact written at the end of a long chat is invisible to that same chat. The boundary is the point.

What belongs there

- A durable preference: concise answers, a citation habit, a language.
- An environment fact the agent cannot cheaply rediscover: this machine, this package manager, this branch rule.
- A convention: tests live here, commits do not mention that.

The same page is clear about what does not belong: a vague "user asked about Python," a fact a web search would refresh, a log dump, a one-off path, and anything already in SOUL.md or AGENTS.md. Credentials belong in the environment, not in memory.

Session search is the other half

Past conversations sit in SQLite at **~/.hermes/state.db**. Session search uses full-text search and, on the memory page, returns actual messages rather than a summary. It is on demand and unbounded, which is why the short files can stay short. **hermes sessions list** shows the archive. The agent is expected to search it when a past detail matters.

Nudges, and Honcho

The product page describes a closed loop: periodic nudges to persist knowledge, skill creation after complex work, and cross-session recall. Honcho is named as an optional dialectic user model. External memory providers run beside the built-in files; they do not replace them. The documented entry points are **hermes memory setup** and **hermes memory status**.

> TIP
> If you want a veto, the memory page documents memory.write_approval. Pending writes can be reviewed with /memory pending, then approved or rejected. Use that on a shared machine.

CHAPTER 04

Skills

A skill is a procedure the agent can load when the job needs it. A prompt is a sentence you will retype.

The features overview calls skills on-demand knowledge documents. They follow a progressive-disclosure pattern so the whole catalogue is not stuffed into every prompt, and they are compatible with the agentskills.io open standard. The product page adds the loop: Hermes can create a skill after complex work, and improve that skill during later use. Community skills arrive through the Skills Hub.

When a skill beats a memory entry

Memory is a fact. A skill is a method. “This repo uses pytest” is memory. “How we triage a failing integration test, including the log path and the rollback” is a skill. The memory page says the same thing from the other side: a location needed on every run of a recurring task often belongs in a skill, not in the character-capped notebook.

A skill worth keeping

- One job, named for the job.
- The inputs it expects, and the file or command that counts as done.
- The steps you actually use, including the failure you always hit.
- An explicit do-not: do not push, do not email, do not rewrite the schema.

> WATCH OUT
> A skill from the Hub is code-shaped instructions running beside your tools. Read it before you enable it on a gateway that can see your messages. Portable does not mean reviewed.

Context files are the project’s voice

Separate from skills, Hermes discovers project context: .hermes.md, AGENTS.md, CLAUDE.md, SOUL.md, and .cursorrules. SOUL.md is the personality and stance. AGENTS.md is the project’s operating note. Put the rule in the file the next session will load. Do not hope the chat remembers it.

CHAPTER 05

Tools, terminals, and checkpoints

The agent is only as contained as the terminal you give it. Checkpoints are the undo for the file edits.

Tools are functions, grouped into toolsets you can enable or disable per platform: web search, terminal, file edits, memory, delegation, and others. The features overview also documents programmatic calling: an execute_code path where the agent writes a script that calls Hermes tools, collapsing a multi-step pipeline into one model turn, inside a sandbox.

Seven places a command can run

The product page lists seven terminal backends: local, Docker, SSH, Daytona, Singularity, Modal, and Vercel Sandbox. Daytona and Modal are described as serverless persistence — the environment hibernates when idle. Local is the convenient default and the dangerous one, because a bad command is a command on your machine.

> REMEMBER
> A container is the security boundary the security page trusts. On a laptop you care about, Docker, Modal, Daytona, or a sandbox backend is the adult setting. Local is for a directory you can delete.

Checkpoints

Before file changes, Hermes snapshots the working directory. If the edit is wrong, **/rollback** is the documented way back. It is not a substitute for git. Commit, or at least know the diff, before you ask for a wide rewrite.

Context references are the other small tool worth learning early. Typing @ and a file, folder, git diff, or URL injects that content into the message. A reference beats a description of a file, for the same reason it does in any assistant.

CHAPTER 06

The gateway

One process, many rooms. The gateway is why Hermes can answer in a chat app without becoming a different agent.

The product page lists the rooms from a single gateway: CLI, Telegram, Discord, Slack, WhatsApp, Signal, Matrix, Mattermost, email, SMS, DingTalk, Feishu, WeCom, Weixin, QQ Bot, Yuanbao, BlueBubbles, Home Assistant, Microsoft Teams, Google Chat, and others — “20+ platforms.” Voice-memo transcription and cross-platform continuity are part of that claim. Sessions, skills, and memory are meant to follow the profile, not the app.

What to connect first

Connect one platform you already check. Telegram and Discord are the usual first rooms because a phone is where a cron result is actually read. Do not connect a work Slack until the approval mode and the allowlist are set. A gateway without an allowlist is a door.

The security page is blunt about strangers. Unknown users are authorised by DM pairing: an 8-character code, expiring in an hour, approved by you from the CLI, with rate limits and lockouts. If no allowlist is set and the allow-all switch is off, the gateway denies users and logs a warning. That default is a feature. Do not “fix” it by allowing everyone.

> WATCH OUT
> Do not run the gateway as root. Do not set GATEWAY_ALLOW_ALL_USERS in anything you would call production. Both are named prohibitions on the security page, not style advice.

CHAPTER 07

Bot Mode, subagents, and cron

Three ways to stop being the middleman: a standing team, a parallel worker, and a clock.

Bot Mode

The product page describes Bot Mode in one sentence that is worth keeping whole: build a durable team of specialist bots that work together in group chats and through @mentions. The intended shape matches a small staff, not one bot with twelve jobs. A research bot, a writing bot, and a triage bot can share a room. You are pulled in for a judgment, not for every step.

Give each bot one lane and a written do-not. A group chat is not a permission upgrade. The bot that can read a repository should not be the bot that can send mail, unless you have decided that on purpose.

Subagents

Delegation is a different mechanism. The delegate_task tool spawns a child agent with isolated context, a restricted toolset, and its own terminal session. The features overview says three concurrent subagents is the default, and that the number is configurable. Isolation is the point: a research child should not inherit the parent's half-finished edit.

Cron

Scheduled tasks take natural language or a cron expression. A job can attach a skill and deliver the result to any connected platform. Pause, resume, and edit are part of the documented surface. A daily digest is the right first schedule. A job that spends money, sends messages, or rewrites files is not a first schedule.

> TIP
> Write the cron job as a skill first, run it once while you watch, then put it on the clock. A schedule amplifies a procedure. It does not invent one.

CHAPTER 08

Voice, browser, and images

These are providers behind tools, not a single magic mode. Know which bill you turned on.

Voice Mode, on the features overview, is full voice on the CLI and on messaging platforms: microphone in, spoken replies out, including live voice in a Discord channel. A wake word — “Hey Hermes” — is documented for the CLI, the TUI, and the desktop app, using an on-device hotword listener. Text-to-speech is a separate list of providers, from a free Edge TTS option to ElevenLabs, OpenAI, MiniMax, Mistral, Gemini, xAI, and local voices such as Piper. Incoming voice memos can be transcribed on the platforms that send them.

Browser

Browser automation has more than one backend: Browserbase, Browser Use, a local Chrome, Brave, Chromium, or Edge through the debugging protocol, or a local Chromium. The agent can navigate, fill, and extract. A browser session is a logged-in session if you logged it in. Treat that cookie jar as a credential.

Images

Vision is pasting an image into the CLI and asking a vision-capable model to read it. Image generation is a different tool, documented against FAL.ai and a set of named models you pick with **hermes tools**. Portal setup bundles generation with search, speech, and browser. A local install without that setup will not grow a paintbrush on its own.

> WATCH OUT
> A generated face or voice of a real person is still that person. Do not aim the image tool or the speech tool at someone who did not agree, and do not aim either at a minor.

CHAPTER 09

Security, stated as habits

The security page describes eight layers. You only have to refuse three shortcuts to benefit from most of them.

The documented model is defence in depth: who may talk to the agent, approval for dangerous commands, file-write blocks on paths such as ~/.ssh and /etc, container isolation, credential filtering for MCP subprocesses, scanning of context files, isolation between sessions, and input checks on the terminal tool.

Approvals

Dangerous commands ask. You can allow once, for the session, or always. Three modes are documented. Smart uses a model to pass low risk, refuse clear danger, and ask on the rest. Manual always asks. Off disables the prompts.

> WATCH OUT
> approvals.mode: off is for a trusted container or a CI job, not for a laptop. YOLO mode disables dangerous-command checks for the session except a hard blocklist. The security page tells you to use it only when you fully trust the commands being generated. That is a high bar. A demo is not that bar.

Three habits

- Manual approvals until a command has earned “always.” Sending, deleting, and paying never earn it on the first week.
- A container backend for any gateway that stays up overnight.
- A profile split, so a messaging bot cannot see the directory that holds keys.

MCP servers extend tools. They also extend reach. The security page strips environment variables from those subprocesses down to a safe set. That helps. It does not review the server. Add an MCP server the way you add a skill: after you know what it can call.

CHAPTER 10

A first-week practice plan

Seven short sessions. Each one uses a different part of Hermes on a folder you can afford to throw away.

Day 1 — Install and a bounded job

Install, run portal setup or point at a key you already have, run hermes doctor, and ask for a README section in a scratch repository. Read the diff.

Day 2 — Memory, then a new session

Tell it one preference and one environment fact. Confirm the lines in MEMORY.md and USER.md. Start /new and ask it to apply both without being reminded.

Day 3 — A skill from a repeated chore

Take a three-step chore you did twice this week. Ask Hermes to save it as a skill with a definition of done and a do-not. Run the skill once.

Day 4 — A checkpoint you actually use

Ask for a refactor you can judge. If it wanders, /rollback, then restate the constraint. The point is the undo, not the refactor.

Day 5 — One gateway, one allowlist

Connect a single messaging platform. Pair yourself. Send a job from the phone. Confirm a stranger is not answered.

Day 6 — One schedule

Attach the Day 3 skill to a cron that delivers a short note to that platform. Run it once by hand first. Pause it if the note is noise.

Day 7 — A second worker, not a second personality

Either a subagent for a parallel read, or a Bot Mode specialist with one lane. Give it no send permission. Compare the result with doing the read yourself.

> TIP
> Keep a page of jobs that worked, with the do-not that made them safe. A library of personalities is useless. A library of boundaries is the manual you will reuse.

APPENDIX

Glossary

If a chapter and a glossary line disagree, follow the chapter. If the install and this book disagree, follow the install.

Term	Means
Bot Mode	Specialist bots in a group chat, addressed with @mentions.
Checkpoint	A snapshot taken before file edits. /rollback returns to it.
Cron	A scheduled job, in natural language or cron syntax, delivered to a platform.
Gateway	The process that connects one Hermes profile to messaging platforms.
MEMORY.md	The agent's capped notebook. Frozen into the prompt at session start.
Nous Portal	Hosted setup for a model plus search, image, speech, and browser tools.
Profile	An isolated Hermes: config, sessions, skills, and memory.
Skill	A loadable procedure, compatible with the agentskills.io standard.
Subagent	A child agent with its own context and terminal. Three concurrent by default.
USER.md	The capped profile of you. Also frozen at session start.
YOLO	A session switch that skips dangerous-command prompts, except a hard blocklist.

Sources used for this edition

- hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/docs — product definition, install lines, feature list.
- Features overview — tools, skills, memory, delegation, voice, browser, cron, checkpoints.
- Persistent memory — MEMORY.md, USER.md, caps, session search, write approval.
- Security — eight layers, approval modes, pairing, container guidance.
- Skin reference — default bronze and gold, used here as the visual language.

Licence in the project's own skill metadata is MIT. Confirm the LICENSE file in the repository you install.

COLOPHON

About this edition

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Feature descriptions were compiled from public documentation for the 2026 Edition. Commands, caps, and platform lists change. The install on your machine is the authority.

2026 EDITION

No calendar day is printed in this edition, by design.